KARNATAKA: A THREE-WAY TUSSLE PG 13

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UPFRONT

MAHARASHTRA: A RUDE JOLT FOR THE BJP PG 15

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TROUBLE IN HEAVEN From a village in Leh valley, a Buddhist monk gazes at the panorama of great Himalayan peaks

SHUTTERSTOCK

LADAKH

LEFT IN THE COLD

By Moazum Mohammad in Srinagar

The harsh winter in the surreal moonscape of Ladakh, with temperatures skimming minus 20 degrees centigrade, is hardly conducive to public protests. Yet hundreds of Ladakhis braved the extreme weather and gathered at Polo Ground in Leh on January 31 to show solidarity with educational reformist and innovator Sonam Wangchuk. The Magsaysay award recipient had just completed a five-day 'climate fast' from January 26 at nearby Phyang to draw attention to Ladakh's fragile ecology, which he says is gravely threatened by uncontrolled development, tourism and commerce. Wangchuk is demanding Ladakh's inclusion in the Sixth Schedule of the Constitution so that Ladakhis can have greater say over every aspect of their land.

Four days before his fast, Wangchuk addressed Prime Minister Narendra Modi in a 13-minute video, 'Ladakh Ki Mann Ki Baat', from Khardung La, one of the world's highest motorable passes. Trudging through snow in temperatures well below freezing point, his message was as clear as the skies over him: over three years after the August 2019 abrogation of Article 370, leading up to the bifurcation of erstwhile Jammu and Kashmir into the Union Territories of Ladakh and J&K, 'all is not well' on India's highest plateau—a strategically key region sharing borders